by no means unexpected. Does the world's so- called largest democracy really want to be seen as a nation revelling in a retrograde, made-for-TV bloodlust?

I began to think of Ghalib, Afzal Guru's fourteen- year-old son, who, accompanied by his mother a few years ago, went to the head of the Indian state with a mercy petition, begging the President to pardon his father's life. Clearly, the President wasn't listening. He had to, as the judge had decreed in the Supreme Court of India's verdict, satisfy the 'collective conscience of the society', which will 'only be satisfied if capital punishment is awarded to the offender'.

It is of course impossible to understand the complex moral arithmetic necessary to arrive at the perfect potion needed to assuage the collective conscience of a billion people. I began to think of writing about it, answering an urge to say what I, and many others, felt. I struggled, despairing about the powerlessness, and perhaps pointlessness, of an op-ed or essay. I also began to feel lonely, for in spite of the proliferation of conversations on social media, a solidarity of the oppressed and the besieged is hard to find amid the buzz of the internet or a postmodern metropolis.

What was the Indian state trying to say, one must ask. Surely, it can't simply be explained, as some analysts have done, as merely a hideous expression of the compulsions of electoral realpolitik in which political parties in India become eager to sink to new moral lows to outdo their rivals. It's a message to the Kashmiri people, an occupying power yelling at the powerless natives that you must bow and genuflect, that the hangman's noose can extend beyond the gallows, casting its dark shadow over children's milk and medicines for old couples.

Two moments seem to have entered history. Kashmiris creating a hollow grave as a mausoleum to memory and resistance and India making a craven declaration: that a Kashmiri corpse can be seditious. It must remain in prison.

This essay was first published in the *Guardian*, 15 February 2013.